



Belt of Productivity, Road to Equality: People First Infrastructure Development in Indonesia

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Introduction

Infrastructure initiative, as an instrument deployed by states and markets to drive economic growth, has become an integral but controversial strategy with a mixed impact on global development praxis, after the realm of development studies stepped into debates around equality that implies effective engagement of civil societies affected (Gibson & Olivia, 2010; Wang et al., 2020). China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) is a momentous infrastructure development game-changer that involves Chinese capital in promoting transcontinental productivity through investment and construction projects (Wang et al., 2020; Senadjki et al., 2022). Facilitated by the President Joko Widodo (Jokowi) Administration, Indonesia has proactively embraced the BRI to establish the Jakarta–Bandung high-speed railway (HSR), ‘*Whoosh*’ (Kim, 2020; Tritto, 2020). The *Whoosh* in Indonesian represents ‘time-saving, optimal operation, great system’ (Rana, 2023)—this HSR plan prompts historic opportunities for interconnectivity and structural transformation. However, implicit power dynamics cross swords, whether by nature or design, in the context of the BRI confronted with disputes over technology, formality, and inclusion, three concepts drawn from development anthropology (Pfaffenberger, 1992; Koster & Smart, 2019; Wijaya, 2021). This essay spotlights the anthropologists’ solutions with a ‘people first’ bottom-up approach that incorporates previously-excluded individuals and apprehends people–power interrelations behind the BRI (Smith, 2008). In this vein, the scrutiny unpacks infrastructure’s metaphor for transformation, and critically dissects the underlying technology determinism to disprove technocracy. Next, this exploration directs our probe at the people-level effects of infrastructure provision on



formal work in Indonesia. Inclusion entailing a keen mind on justice, the analysis interrogates the empowerment role of knowledge to unfold its influence on communities' participation in the dynamics of business and politics. With the thread from tech-oriented infrastructure to livelihoods and knowledge as the BRI's connotation, the essay narrows its scope but explores deeper, linking the HSR project case studies with people's everyday lives and empowerment.

Technology: Infrastructure's Metaphor for Transformation

Indonesia's attempt to cultivate technology has motivated its collaboration with China's BRI. Considering the anthropology of technology, infrastructure, a materialisation of technology constituting the interconnectivity and consequent structural transformation, is embedded in the sociotechnical system and (re)shapes individuals' cognition of their surrounding world (Pfaffenberger, 1992). Therefore, infrastructure operates as both a physical and metaphorical bridge for communication (Ding et al., 2008), which could boost cross-regional productivity regarding technologism, with paths controversial but outcomes recognised. Utilising 'big push' network effects (Rosenstein-Rodan, 1943) and coordinating public facilities (Nurkse, 1953; Hirschman, 1958), technology-focused 'Big D' interventions activate capital in social reproduction and accumulation (Lewis, 2019; Mawdsley & Taggart, 2022). With the same goals of productivity-oriented development, Rosenstein-Rodan (1943) and Nurkse (1953) believed that simultaneously evenly investing in multiple sectors would expand the domestic market to stimulate transformation, whilst Hirschman (1958) prioritised several leading sectors to incentivise backward-connected industries—despite fascinating wrangles on (un)balanced priorities, the discussions direct towards a convergence: infrastructure acts as a beneficial 'free ride' for diverse sectors due to its nature of linkages inducing the demands of individuals. In accordance with technology determinism in anthropology, people's needs are constructed (Pfaffenberger, 1992). For example, infrastructure shares material wealth, accelerating the shift to more effective economic activities (Hausmann et al., 2007; Holz, 2011), which frames people's will in a morally favorable manner. Consequently, the government of Indonesia fuelled its 'development agents'—national development financial institutions (NDFIs)—with Jakarta-Bandung HSR *Whoosh* as a cornerstone of prosperity (Shi



& Huang, 2014; Mazzucato & Penna, 2016; Wijaya & Nursamsu, 2020). The arguments on complex causality assert that investing in infrastructure is an outcome of a more prosperous economy but not a catalyst (Holtz-Eakin, 1994). Yet, the studies should not misinterpret the positive correlation between infrastructure and productivity. In a word, Indonesia rationally allocated its resources to infrastructure technology targeting social and economic capacity.

Allocation of resources would be problematic if participatory democracy dysfunctions since interconnectivity remains fundamental and requires consultation and consent before any transformation (Le Billon & Middelorp, 2021, pp. 74–87). Who takes charge, who makes a deal—for power relations, the blueprint of connecting various destinations and communities would fall flat without socio-political mobilisation and people’s support (McAdam, 2012). For example, critics consider tech-centric interventions mired in resistance to technological determinism that is, in Indonesia, spurred by anti-foreign sentiment among the people being tied (Aspinall, 2015; Tritto, 2020). As this determinism insinuates a coercive interventionist crux, it could probably be a tool captured by global superpowers thanks to sovereign debt, inherently harmful to people (Tritto, 2020). Ergo, from the perspective of ‘people first’, it is vital to move beyond the political economy to the social implications of, and the more urgent people’s responses to, the intricacy between development and technology (Marx, 2010). Principally, people’s entwined livelihoods must be accounted for by not only Jokowi’s deal with Chinese capital but also policymaking for formality and inclusion.

Although technologism has never been a silver bullet, a grassroots-engaged system could maximise the potential of the BRI infrastructure movement when putting people first. For instance, under a nuanced and socially conscious procedure to realise a balance between market-driven and state-led modes, the capital scarcity of Global South hinders communities’ reliance on either (Kim, 2020). The interests and concerns of civil societies require NDFIs to extend beyond remedying market failures to Schumpeterian industrial evolution (Mazzucato, 2013). The echoes propel an entrepreneurial state intertwined with philanthrocapitalism to avoid dispossession, including people-centric innovation and social entrepreneurship (Reich, 2018; Haydon et al., 2021) as a commitment to equality that rejects the Third World as a ‘lab’

for development experimentation (McGoey, 2021). These above tradeoffs and compromises are generated by considerations of local communities, as a whole or separately. Besides, based on this engagement, stakeholders, such as policy banks and giant conglomerates from China, were synergised to back up Indonesia's global and local ambitions (Oh, 2018). Available investigations perceive Chinese capital as brimming with flexibility since the joint venture PT KCIC secured exceeding \$5.5 billion without any government guarantee or interference (Aidoo & Hess, 2015; Pavličević & Kratz, 2018; Kratz & Pavličević, 2019; Tritto, 2020). For its substantial impact, counterarguments claim that China might pose a threat—conversely, HSR diplomacy obeyed a business-to-business rule due to its concession for cooperation with local people (Pavličević & Kratz, 2018; Oh, 2018). In closing, supported by the community-engaged system, Indonesia has effectively leveraged the 'people first' stance to bargain with not only domestic policymakers but also Chinese capital, exemplifying a trend towards recognition and procedural justice versus technocracy wherein the elite decides. In other words, it has capitalised on technology determinism interlaced with HSR infrastructure—to respect more than dominate the will of the people.

Formality: Livelihoods within Industries

Formality in employment and informality exhibit obvious disparities concerning substantial advantages for the workforce across various dimensions. According to international standards (Koster & Smart, 2019; International Labour Organization, 2020), the differences are as follows: first, formal employment provides a predictable income for the workers since the establishment of an employment relationship comes with explicit contractual agreements and wage structures. Second, a lucid set of regulatory stipulations governs working conditions. Additionally, a comprehensive social security framework covers more than insurance and pension schemes. By contrast, people within the informal economy often suffer from job uncertainty and income volatility, contending with intolerable working conditions (Conover et al., 2022). With a 'people first' approach, given that the import of infrastructure technology could be a blessing more than a curse with public engagement, the will of communities for formality directs our focus towards people's livelihoods within industries and markets where

labour emerges as a sustainable avenue surpassing subsidies and cash transfers to mitigate poverty (Mills, 1999). Jokowi's policy features a pragmatic desire that infrastructure delivery posits technology work in industries and markets as a cure for informality (Kim, 2020; Wijaya & Nursamsu, 2020).

Since China's BRI brings solid linkages for structural transformation, Indonesia has pursued formality by incentivising industries along the *Whoosh* based on the externalities of this HSR infrastructure (Senadjki et al., 2022). As the world's fourth most populous nation, Indonesia grapples with a complex geography of scattered islands, annoyed by the difficulty of fostering connected entrepreneurial dynamism or harnessing market mechanisms (Wijaya & Nursamsu, 2020). Against this backdrop, the *Whoosh* serves not only as an economic catalyst but an algorithm to decode the isolation and disconnection: narrowing economic and cultural distances has improved the connectivity of entrepreneurship across cities, regencies, and even countries in Asia (Wang et al., 2020; Senadjki et al., 2022). For example, with the multidimensional connections, Indonesia Morowali Industrial Park (IMIP) departed from the development paths proven feasible by its own experience and demonstrated characteristics of China's Special Economic Zones (Zeng, 2010), but also contextualised to suit its host-region circumstances (Tritto & Camba, 2022, p. 7). Within the formal livelihoods working for IMIP industries, Indonesian employees not only earn income but establish their trust and resilience (Tritto & Camba, 2022) due to the interconnectivity culminates in both economic autonomy and livelihood diversification (Gibson & Olivia, 2010). In this scenario, Indonesian people request to be educated as skilled workers embedded into the socio-economic-technical system of technology and capitalism (Pfaffenberger, 1992; Escobar, 1995; Damuri et al., 2019).

Nonetheless, although the interlinkage was built, long-established social inequality still deprives several social groups of meaningful participation in decent work throughout the infrastructure chain (Wijaya, 2021). Since the gender disparity persists, a poignant issue emerges in labour relations when the employment of women, an instance for informality and marginality, remains circumscribed, who are, different from men, blocked from their merited formality with wage, training, and insurance (Choi et al., 2023)—in 2020, compared to men's



82%, women's labour participation rate was only 53% (Dwitami, 2021). Further, transport has already shortened distances between women and economic activities, but the convenience of space fails to fix the predicaments—including early marriage and bullying that encourage social inequality by ruining equitable education (Yarrow & Afkar, 2020; Wijaya, 2021). In another case for education in Kabupaten Probolinggo, the percentage of boys enrolled was about 1.5 times more than that of girls (Yarrow & Afkar, 2020). To sum up, the scarcity of inclusive education in Indonesia has thwarted its progress towards equality of formality in infrastructure work (Damuri et al., 2019). For this reason, Jokowi's pragmatic pursuit of inclusion by adopting contextualised policy instruments in education and empowerment emerges as an essential formula for deciphering the extension of occupational inequality amid BRI-induced structural transformation.

Inclusion: Knowledge Empowerment against Marginality

The BRI has engendered bittersweet spillover effects within the economic corridor containing Indonesia. Despite laudatory acknowledgments of investment and employment, the nuanced scrutiny reveals a confluence of perspectives—discerning observers, including the advocates ever marginalised, highlight a thought-provoking caveat: not all infrastructure undertakings yield affirmative outcomes for all social groups (Gibson & Olivia, 2010; Wijaya, 2021). Just as Indonesian rural non-farm economy (Gibson & Olivia, 2010), access to newly-installed infrastructure occasionally disrupts traditional economic activities, while worsening quality of previously-constructed one precipitates calamity in scattered non-agricultural sectors—a dilemma of infrastructure delivery for subsistence. Since livelihoods are closely linked with traditional economy, the establishment and maintenance of infrastructure are so important that insufficient attention to sustainability provokes heightened exploitation within vulnerable groups governed by social norms, thereby exacerbating inequality and informality (Kohsaka & Rogel, 2019)—this intensification hence looms in infrastructure provision, as segments of the populace defined by gender, race, or class perceive themselves excluded from Indonesia's grand ambition of productivity and formality (Wijaya, 2021).



As for specific people-level influence, progress occurs with sustainability in the BRI. In the tradition-bound areas scarred by entrenched discrimination (Li, 2014), individuals once excluded have now, commendably, secured access to resources and equally communicated with foreign professionals due to the opportunities of education or training prompted by, directly or indirectly, infrastructure interconnectivity. For the implementation of the HSR program, relevant institutions offer specialised training to the local workforce; during the BRI cooperation, China facilitates the development of education system in countries along the initiative or provides education for international students (Pratiwi, 2020; Yue et al., 2022). The ascendancy of knowledge is incontrovertible for engagement; hence, the effectuality of empowerment blueprints appended to BRI endeavours is pronounced: those people would be aptly equipped with the requisite expertise to engage in infrastructure technology work to foster the assimilation of indispensably transferred knowledge (Gibson & Olivia, 2010). In essence, the BRI interplay necessitates a judicious evaluation to introspect the engagement of disadvantaged groups and revisit knowledge-centred empowerment.

However, while Jokowi's aspirations to instigate knowledge mobilisation as a panacea for poverty via the BRI are laudable (Kim, 2020; Wijaya & Nursamsu, 2020), a noticeable social inequality survives. Disproportionately unequal endowments of devices and education generated higher digital literacy rates among men than women which could be vivid proof fomenting the imbalance (Gibson & Olivia, 2010). Hence, recognising that rural migration cannot transition all individuals into urban industrial workers, imperative measures involve training and support of them to optimally allocate their labour force when the 'villagers' have only agricultural experience and few transferable skills (Sangadji et al., 2019). Accordingly, Indonesia established polytechnics and schools jointly with Chinese-backed businesses, then employing translators and offering Mandarin modules equally to their employees (Tritto & Camba, 2022, p. 5). In short, the pivotal role of educational empowerment in advancing inclusion could never be overstated, whilst the meticulous diffusion of knowledge underpins cooperation with stakeholders and communities.

Moreover, the multifaceted core of the transformative progress over the HSR *Whoosh*

infrastructure development reminds policymakers and academics to grasp bottom-up opinions and perspectives from people on the front lines of empowerment (Smith, 2008). Enabled by the teaching sessions aforespecified, interactions between BRI institutions and indigenous communities gradually reached a consensus on people's involvement in not only the market economy but also socio-political democracy (De Haan, 2015; He & Tritto, 2022). With the infrastructure project merely as a platform for facilitation, the control by these backers, e.g., Chinese international financial institutions, Indonesian governors, mayors, and regents, and central governments of both, has little by little faded to business actors as the representative of people's consultation (Tritto & Camba, 2022, p. 8). In other words, this education allows local communities to struggle against exclusion, sharing knowledge for economic autonomy and socio-political participation through business players. In brief, knowledge functions targeted at combating informality, marginality, and inequality under both opportunities and challenges triggered by the BRI and *Whoosh*.

Conclusion

In conclusion, although China's BRI offers numerous opportunities for interconnectivity and structural transformation, the influence of power dynamics within the initiative is complex for both positive and negative implications. While the infrastructure strengthens productivity and promotes equality, the means and perspectives to use and view are decisive: to be, or not to be—to be productivity transformation, decent work, and inclusive growth, or to be technocracy, informality, and marginality—that is a question. The 'people first' approach keeps scholars and policymakers concerned about the potential consequences of exploitation and dispossession. When infrastructure technology (re)creates the needs of a state and its residents, integrated planning and management of investment and construction should align with formality and inclusion for the communities' vision. Overall, practitioners and academics must be mindful of their methodology usage and highly recognise local perspectives valuing people first.

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